

same year and has since then been performed more than 150 times across the globe. More recently, Roysten Abel has toured the world with his plays. First *Othello in Black and White* which won the Scotsman Fringe First Award at the Edinburgh fringe festival in 1999, then *The Beggar's Opera* in 2001 and *Dami al Meno un Raje di Sole*, a play based on the legendary Italian filmmaker Federico Fellini and performed in his hometown Rimini, in

closer links between the theatre communities of both countries". Airan Berg, artistic director, Performing Arts of Linz (Austria), who is on an extensive tour of India scouting for artistes, says, "I'm not here to shop for plays, but to create a collaboration between artistes in India and Linz, and facilitate an exchange of ideas as well as performances."

Berg is the first, but there are many more who will follow. As for theatre itself, while the smaller experimental

the slowly diminishing community of snake charmers, who have been banned from using snakes in performances. When the show went to Teatro di San Carlo in Naples, Italy, Abel says of the 100 performers, "99 were getting onto a plane for the very first time".

Even as AMSND tours across India in the coming weeks, another international production with an Indian touch, theatre and dance diva Piná Bausch's *Bamboo Blues*, will be staged in select cities across the country.

The other giant on the international theatre scene, who has been working with artistes in Kerala and the Manganiyars in Rajasthan for a future production is French director Ariane Mnouchkine of the world renowned Theatre du Soleil. Even devoted followers of "small and intimate" theatre like Rehaan Engineer of the Industrial Theatre Company look set to dream big with over-the-top productions. His new project is a musical *Into the Woods*, an ambitious production by Stephen Sondheim and James Lapine, which will be staged in Mumbai soon. Not to be outdone, Supple has already started work on *Peter Pan*, his next play with an Indian cast.

But the AMSND experience is one he treasures. "I don't think the cast has been involved with anything like the scale of AMSND, he says, pointing to street performers Ram Pawar and Lakhan Pawar, aged nine and ten, who have decided to become professional actors.

Sets inspired by Jaipur's Hawa Mahal and Amsterdam's Red Light district, musicians sourced from remote districts of Rajasthan, Shakespeare's lines being mouthed in regional languages, this is an East-West encounter that is all set to go beyond the merely exotic.



MANGANIYAR SEDUCTION

Conceptualised by Roysten Abel, the cast comprises 50 folk musicians from Rajasthan and the sets comprise 36 red-curtained and back-lit boxes. It was staged at Salzburg and Tivoli and will open the Halle Festival in Germany in June followed by tour of Europe and Asia.

2002. But AMSND is largely responsible for the world waking up to modern Indian theatrical spectacles. Thiyam's productions in Manipuri are considered an amalgam of folk and classical art forms, while Abel toured sporadically on invitation, but AMSND has been on a non-stop tour across the world for the past year-and-a-half which is probably why its impact has been felt so intensively by the Western theatre community.

The last time India was in the news on the world stage was during Peter Brook's *The Mahabharata* in 1985 which had only a token Indian presence—Mallika Sarabhai in Draupadi's role. The Indian theatre scene is now buzzing with action with festival directors from Germany, France and the UK touring India, the latest being a cultural delegation that arrived from the Netherlands, to "view and understand modern Indian theatre and establish

plays continue to gather a strong and dedicated audience, it certainly looks like big times are here to roll for Indian theatre, in terms of mega

productions that guarantee a crossover audience in the West. Besides AMSND, the other major productions touring the world from India include Thiyam's *Prologue* which was premiered in 2007 and Abel's *Manganiyar Seduction* which reverses the process in creating a production that uses theatre to showcase music. Abel's play features more than 50 Manganiyars or folk musicians from Rajasthan and has won acclaim both in India and abroad. Abel will also continue to tour with *A Hundred Charmers* conceived by the Jeevika Foundation to create awareness about